4.1 Landmark Amendments and Terrible Loss

The end of slavery was a great moral victory for the nation. But it became a source of rage for some—rage that triggered violence and terrible loss.

MAIN IDEA Abraham Lincoln planned to rebuild the South and restore the Union, but others would have to follow through for him.

SLAVERY IS ABOLISHED

In January 1865, three months before Lee would surrender, Congress passed the **13th Amendment**, which prohibited slavery in the United States. As with all amendments, it was sent to the states for ratification. By December 1865, three-quarters of the states had approved it, and the 13th Amendment was added to the Constitution.

Slavery was over. Georgia, a former Confederate state, provided the final vote needed for ratification. The amendment states, "Neither slavery nor involuntary **servitude** [being enslaved] . . . shall exist within the United States, or any place subject to their **jurisdiction** [the authority to enforce laws within a given area]." The 13th Amendment abolished slavery, but African Americans were not guaranteed full equality under the law until 1868, with the ratification of the **14th Amendment**. African-American men received voting rights when the **15th Amendment** was ratified in 1870.

Outlawing the practice of slavery was a giant step toward equality and justice. However, discrimination and racism did not magically disappear with the passage of the 13th, 14th, and 15th Amendments. African Americans were frequent victims of violence at the hands of whites. With few options for employment, many southern African Americans went back to work on plantations, where they earned poverty-level wages. Further, African Americans could not depend on a legal system that still favored whites.

LINCOLN'S ASSASSINATION

After the Civil War ended, Lincoln's primary goal was, once again, reuniting the nation. He recognized that integrating newly freed African Americans into society and rebuilding the physical and social structures of the South would be a delicate operation. He planned to implement measures to remedy the injustices of slavery, bring the former Confederate states back into the Union, and rebuild the South.

These plans became known as **Reconstruction**. Lincoln knew he would have to act with careful diplomacy in order to carry out these measures without inflaming already volatile racial and sectional tensions. However, he realized some issues would cause an uproar, no matter the diplomacy used in proposing them. For example, on April 11, 1865, he suggested that some African-American men should have the right to vote. As you have read, that right would not be guaranteed for another five years.

Just three days later on April 14, 1865, **John Wilkes Booth**, an actor and Confederate sympathizer, fatally shot Lincoln at Ford's Theatre in Washington, D.C., as the president watched a play. Audience members rushed the president from Ford's Theatre to the Petersen House, a boarding house across the street. Lincoln never regained consciousness, and he died the next morning. For the first time in U.S. history, a sitting president had been **assassinated**, or murdered for political reasons.

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On April 21, Lincoln's funeral train began a somber journey to Springfield, Illinois, where he had lived before becoming president. Thousands of Americans lined the train's route to mourn. Lincoln was buried on May 4, 1865.

Vice President **Andrew Johnson** succeeded Lincoln as president. Johnson favored Lincoln's Reconstruction policies, but he lacked Lincoln's leadership skills. Also, Republican congressmen distrusted him because he was a former Democrat and former slaveholder.

Johnson could not stop Congress from enacting harsh penalties on the southern states. In particular, the **Radical Republicans** believed the former Confederacy should be punished for secession and war. Their treatment of the South caused long-standing resentment and discontent among many southerners.

Lincoln's steady leadership had brought an end to the Civil War. Following his death, the nation struggled to regain a true sense of unity as it rebuilt without the leader who had saved it. The far-reaching consequences of his loss were yet to be realized. The morning he died, Lincoln's Secretary of War, Edwin M. Stanton, is reported to have said either, "Now he belongs to the ages" or "Now he belongs to the angels." For Americans in 1865, both statements rang true.

Chicago History Museum

After Lincoln was shot, he was taken to a small bedroom in the Petersen House and laid in this bed, diagonally, because he was so tall. Today, you can see Lincoln's death bed at the Chicago History Museum. *The Last Hours of Abraham Lincoln,* painted by Alonzo Chappel in 1868, hangs above the bed. It dramatizes Lincoln's last hours, features Mary Todd Lincoln weeping on his chest, and includes many of the people who visited Lincoln before he died.



HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did Lincoln plan to reunite and heal the nation after the Civil War?
2. **ANALYZE LANGUAGE USE** What do you think is meant by the phrase "or any place subject to their jurisdiction" in the 13th Amendment?
3. **EVALUATE** In what ways did Lincoln's assassination affect Reconstruction and attitudes in the South?

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